

Council Meeting
June 26, 2024
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The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, June 26, 2024, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 6:00 p.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne – Lef at 7:04 P.M.

Ward II Councilor Brian Zutter

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Hayden

Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau

At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway

At-Large Councilor William Limoges

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski

Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Yoshi Manale, City Manager

CITY COUNCILOR - AT LARGE INTERVIEWS

Mayor Girard started the Councilor At Large interviews. The first interview was with John Woods-Giosi.

The Council took a brief break until Interviewee William Greenrose arrived, as he was unaware of the time change of the Council Meeting.

William Greenrose was then interviewed by the City Council, both candidates were asked the same questions.

Mayor Girard asked Ms. Bizzarro for a roll-call where each sitting Councilor votes who they would want as the At-Large Councilor.

Roll call:

Koloski – Greenrose

Limoges - Greenrose

Matteau – Greenrose

Zutter- Greenrose

Hemingway – Greenrose

Hayden – Greenrose

**O'Hearne – Woods-Giosi
Girard - Greenrose**

Motion carried 7-1, in favor of Greenrose

AGENDA CHANGES

Manager Manale requested to remove Ordinance 630 Item A under New Business because the law firm who worked on this Ordinance used outdated information, and wants to bring it back with corrections.

Councilor Hayden asked for the Charter Amendment to be placed on an agenda.

By consensus the City Council agreed the Charter Amendment would be placed on a future agenda.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept the minutes of the June 12, 2024, City Council meeting.

Councilor Heminway noted on May 29th he abstained from the vote for approval of the minutes as he was absent. Assistant Mayor Matteau and Councilor Limoges were okay with this change.

Voice vote:

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose – Recuse
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Batchelder – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
O'Hearne – yes
Girard – yes**

Motion carried 8-0, 1 recused

MAYOR'S NOTES

Mayor Girard noted on July 2nd the Community Center will host a meeting to discuss the tennis and pickle ball courts project at 5:30 p.m.

July 3rd will be the 4th of July celebration from 6 p.m. to 10 p.m. fireworks at 9:30, with a rain date of July 5th.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Manager Manale shared on June 12 our DPW director saw two kids on the Amtrack High Bridge over Main Street, Rt 103, knowing the trains cross that bridge around 5:30 to 6:00 p.m. Director Gleeson called dispatch to inform them. Darrell Limoges quickly called the railroad emergency dispatch, and Amtrack was 10 minutes from the bridge, the train was traveling at 79 mph at the time. However, with the advanced warning the train was able to slow down to give the kids a chance to get off the bridge. The train engineer called back and noted if Alex and Darrell had not let them know, those kids would have been killed as there is nowhere to go but to jump. Manager Manale thanked Alex Gleeson and Darrell Limoges for their quick thinking.

There will be a proposed adjustment on elderly and disabled tax exemptions on the next agenda.

Senator Hassan and Senator Shaheen's office have notified us that the US DOT has awarded a \$1,466,700.00 2024 RAISE Grant, Mr. Manale noted this is one of the most competitive programs where only two cities in the state are awarded, and the targeted section is Charlestown Road.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Mayor Girard gave reminder that Citizen's forum is designed to allow you the opportunity to make the Council aware of your concerns. Please state your name and ward number, we ask you to address your concerns directly to the Council. The Council Manager will not be responding to you during this time. You are limited to five minutes on any non-agenda items. In the back of the room please write down your contact information if you'd like to be contacted as well as your concern on the clipboard for follow up.

Aaron Feustel, Ward I, shared concern of the City not allowing him to dig on his property in concern of damaging a city tree.

Heidi Hood, Ward II, thanked the Council for listening to what was said at the last meeting and actually fixing some sidewalks. Ms. Hood noted there is still lots of areas that needs to be fixed such as: Summer St. near the high school, Maple Ave, Pleasant St, and near the Hitching Post.

Mike Tetu, Ward I, thanked Councilor Hayden for the charter amendment, and congratulated Councilor Greenrose, and suggested the splash pad is a nice idea, but would like to see any money coming in from tax deeded properties go to phase 1 of Washington St. re-paving.

Norm, Ward III, Shared concern for clean water.

OLD BUSINESS

Councilor O’Hearne left at 7:04 P.M.

Manager Manale, read off questions directed from the Mayor and City Council from Previous meetings, and clarified with answers from DPW. Then re-reviewed the Highway, water, and sewer Budgets. Manager Manale also explained wanting to get a lease schedule up to date, and bring back leases to the City Council as well as coming up with a City-Wide Lease plan, and noted an internal discussion to amend our purchasing policy with a standard of leases so everyone would follow the same practice for leasing.

Mayor Girard noted coming up with a standardized lease policy is important, and thinks it’s a good idea.

Director Bates suggested reviewing leases prior to future budget meetings, and noted reviewing leases should be done earlier in the process going forward.

Mayor Girard asked Council if all agreed they were good with the 3 budgets and to move on from them.

By consensus the Council agrees.

Ordinance 629 2024 Non-Union Employee Merit Scale Plan Attachment C Adjustment

Director Young re-introduced Ordinance 629, Councilor Koloski recused himself and Manager Manale stated there are no changes from the last reading, and noted this is for retention and trying to be competitive with surrounding communities, and feels this is necessary for recruitment.

A motion was made by Councilor Hemingway and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to pass Ordinance 629 to a third and final reading on July 10th, 2024 Council meeting.

Councilor Hemingway read explanation of proposed action into record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – Recused

Greenrose - yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 7-0, (1 recused)

Resolution 2024-41 USDA Rural Business Development Grant

Director Merrill, noted this is a USDA grant that was applied for in the winter and was brought to you by the City Manager in a report. It really focuses on small businesses, allowing resources for small businesses, and will also allow the Hannah Grimes Center in Keene to bring their services here.

Councilor Zutter shared concerns for planning grants, and noted after reading the memo and resolutions it seems this is for execution; Services to small businesses.

Director Merrill agreed and noted this will attract small businesses who wants to start but doesn't know how.

Councilor Greenrose asked if these services would help businesses with grant writing, because a lot of small businesses don't understand the process or language.

Director Merrill stated yes, and the USDA has energy money for the private sector businesses and many can't figure out how to use these programs, but this would allow them to get educated.

A motion was made by Councilor Koloski and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept Resolution 2024-41.

Councilor Koloski read resolution 2024-41 into the record.

Mayor Girard opened a Public Hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Mayor Girard noted not wanting to see anymore planning grants coming to Council, and asked what kind of time frame will this be spent over, Director Merrill replied twelve months.

Councilor Hemingway noted he was originally against this, and wants to see action.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose - yes

Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

NEW BUSINESS

Washington Street Options

Manager Manale gave an overview of last week's assessment meeting, and noted Director Gleeson is here for any questions on the scope of the project. Manager Manale then presented Bonding with a five-, ten-, and fifteen-year bond. However, suggesting the five-year bond and the first payment wouldn't be until 2026.

Councilor Koloski asked if this would cover the center of the roads or the entire road.

Manager Manale noted this would be for the entire road, and noted there was a previous concern about the lifespan of the road compared to the cost of re-paying the bond.

Councilor Limoges noted he would rather do the repairs in its entirety.

Councilor Koloski stated he has a hard time explaining to tax payers repairing the entire road when certain sections were just re-done, and about a mile of this road is intact.

Manager Manale noted 2.3 miles of road has been neglected for forty years, and pieced together in the past. Many people think this is the most important road in the City, and does not agree with it being piecemealed together.

Mayor Girard asked when the outside lanes were done. Director Gleeson noted the full width reconstruction was last done in the mid-eighties.

Director Merrill noted Washington and Bowen intersection was re-done through a state safety grant.

Councilor Koloski suggested the Council to drive up and down the road and take a look at intersections, condition of roads, and then noted he can't support bonding the entire paving of Washington.

Manager Manale clarified by asking if Councilor Koloski is suggesting to use existing funds, Councilor Koloski replied yes.

Councilor Hayden had a concern for efficiency by using perpetual band aids piecemealing the road together, and noted if paving was done all at once the City can maintain it easier, and properly plan and budget for repairs in future master plans.

Councilor Zutter concurs with Councilor Hayden.

Assistant Mayor Matteau stated being in favor of paving the entire road with this bid and noted inflation is volatile. Also noting paving is something the City doesn't deal well with, and suggested next year's budget and going forward wanting to see more money into paving, and thinks this is a reasonable amount to pay over 5 years to pave Washington St.

Councilor Zutter stated if this is done now, the City will have twelve to fifteen years to prepare for next repairs, it's an opportunity to refresh a major thruway and plan for future budgeting.

Councilor Koloski asked about a curb cut study, and Manager Manale noted that can go to the TAC.

By consensus the City Council agrees to bring a resolution back for bonding at the next meeting.

FY2025 – Public Hearing and Vote

Resolution 2025-2 To Adopt the 2025 General Fund Budget for the City of Claremont

Mayor Girard noted there needs to be two changes to the resolution.

The first change was Fire from \$2,894,425.00 to \$ 2,893,898.00.

The second change was General, Interest, State from \$5,346,219, to \$5,327,069.

A motion was made by Councilor Hemingway and seconded by Councilor Limoges to accept Resolution 2025-2.

Councilor Hemingway read resolution 2025-2 into the record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing

By consensus the Council put this vote on hold to review position ordinances first and then go back to budget.

Mayor Girard closed the public hearing at 9:31p.m.

Roll call: (roll call vote for General Fund was made after the discussions on Ord 625,627, and 628)

**Koloski – yes
Greenrose - yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 8-0**

Ordinance 625, 2024 Non-Union Employee Classification Plan Attachment B- Business Development Coordinator/Deputy Director of Planning and Development

Manager Manale explained the position.

Assistant Mayor Matteau noted for several years she has been trying to get a housing specialist onboard, and stated the City is not doing nearly enough to solve this, and is hoping this position doesn't get eaten up with other special projects without driving housing forward.

A motion was made by Councilor Hemingway and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept the Ordinance to a second reading at the July 10th Council Meeting.

Councilor Hemingway read explanation of proposed action into record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

**Roll call:
Koloski – yes
Greenrose - yes
Limoges - yes
Matteau – yes
Zutter – yes
Hemingway – yes
Hayden – yes
Girard – yes
Motion carried 8-0**

Ordinance 627, 2024 Non-Union Employee Classification Plan Attachment B- City Treasurer

Director Young explained this would re-grade the City Treasurer to grade 11 instead of 10.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Zutter to accept ordinance to a second reading at the July 10th Council meeting.

Assistant Mayor Matteau read the explanation of proposed action into record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose - yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Ordinance 628, 2024 Non-Union Employee Classification Plan Attachment B- Chief Building Inspector and Health Officer

Director Young explained this would re-grade the position from a grade 9 to a grade 10.

A motion was made by Councilor Limoges and seconded by Councilor Koloski to accept ordinance 628 to a second reading at the July 10th council meeting.

Councilor Limoges read the explanation of proposed action into record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose - yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Resolution 2025-3 To Adopt the 2025 Water Division Budget for the City of Claremont

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Koloski to accept resolution 2025-3.

Assistant Mayor Matteau read resolution 2025-3 into the record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose - yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Mayor Girard asked Director Bates for an update on where we are for a tax rate.

Resolution 2025-4 To Adopt the 2025 Sewer Division Budget for the City of Claremont

A motion was made by Councilor Hayden and seconded by Assistant Mayor Matteau to accept resolution 2025-4.

Councilor Hayden read resolution 2025-4 into the record.

Mayor Girard opened a public hearing, no one spoke. Mayor Girard closed the public hearing.

Roll call:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose - yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Councilor Hemingway reported the Policy Committee is still working on code of conduct and gave a call out for volunteers on the energy advisory committee.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Director Bates and Manager Manale had an update for Mayor Girard for the tax rate. Manager Manale stated it was an eight-cent decrease at 10.49 while the proposed number was 10.57.

Assistant Mayor Matteau wants to see a housing task force set up soon.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 9:41 p.m., a motion was made by Assistant Mayor Matteau and seconded by Councilor Zutter to adjourn.

Voice vote:

Koloski – yes

Greenrose - yes

Limoges - yes

Matteau – yes

Zutter – yes

Hemingway – yes

Hayden – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 8-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro
Clerk to the Council